

Word family: work / worked / working / worker / workable / workmanship / workplace / workforce / workshop / overwork / overworked

Base word: work

Verb forms: work, works, worked, working

Related forms: worker, working, workable, workmanship

Useful family extensions: workplace, workforce, workshop, overwork, overworked

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞) / adjective-related forms (相關形容詞)

Your sentence:

“I saw it about a year ago when I was watching television late at night **after work**.”

A full semantic sweep confirms that **work is one of English's richest everyday words**.

Its major modern concepts include:

1. employment / doing your job;
2. effort or labour;
3. a task or amount of work;
4. creative/intellectual output;
5. a machine/system functioning;
6. a method/plan being effective;
7. operating or controlling something;
8. shaping or processing material;
9. gradually causing a change;
10. several important employment patterns such as **work for / work as / work at / work in**.

I'll keep phrasal verbs such as **work out, work up, work through** excluded under our standing rule.

Meaning in your passage

Here:

after work

means:

after finishing the speaker's normal employment duties / after the working day had ended.

繁體中文：下班後；完成當天工作之後

Natural translation:

"I was watching television late at night after work."

「我當時下班後深夜正在看電視。」

Here, **work** refers to:

一個人的受僱工作／日常工作職責，以及完成這些工作的工作時段

So:

after work

= 下班後

not literally:

「在工作這件東西之後」.

1. work = employment/job activity (受僱工作) — 工作；職業活動

This is your original sense.

Meaning: The activity you do as part of your job or employment.

Practice 1 — Original

"I watched television **after work**."

「我下班後看電視。」

Practice 2

“I have a lot of **work** today.”

「我今天有很多工作要做。」

Practice 3

“She is tired after a long day at **work**.”

「她工作了一整天後感到很累。」

work — employment = 為職業、工作崗位或僱主而進行的日常工作活動

Usually uncountable:

work 

a work  when you mean employment generally

2. be at work (人) — 正在工作; 在工作場所

Practice 4

“She is **at work** right now.”

「她現在正在上班／在工作。」

Practice 5

“I left my headphones **at work**.”

「我把耳機留在了工作地點／公司。」

at work can mean either:

1. 正在工作
2. 在工作場所

Context determines the Chinese.

3. go to work / leave work / finish work (工作日程) — 上班／下班／完成工作

These are essential employment constructions.

Practice 6

“I **go to work** by train.”

「我乘火車上班。」

Practice 7

“What time do you **finish work**?”

「你幾點下班／完成工作？」

work here refers to the speaker's normal employment activity rather than one specific task.

4. work for + employer (僱主／公司／機構) — 為.....工作

This is one of the key grammar patterns.

Practice 8

“She **works for** a technology company.”

「她為一家科技公司工作。」

Practice 9

“He used to **work for** the government.”

「他以前為政府工作。」

work for + employer = 受僱於某人、公司或機構並替其工作

5. work as + job/position (職業／職位) — 擔任.....; 從事.....工作

Practice 10

“She **works as** a designer.”

「她擔任設計師。」

Practice 11

“He **worked as** a teacher for ten years.”

「他曾經擔任教師十年。」

work as + job = 以某個職業／職位身分工作

6. work at/in + workplace (工作地點／公司／機構) — 在.....工作

Practice 12

“She **works at** a hospital.”

「她在醫院工作。」

Practice 13

“He **works in** a bank.”

「他在銀行工作。」

A useful tendency:

- **work at** → specific workplace/institution
- **work in** → building, field, industry, department, environment

But there is overlap.

7. work in + field/industry (行業／專業領域) — 從事……行業／領域

Practice 14

“She **works in** advertising.”

「她從事廣告業。」

Practice 15

“He wants to **work in** technology.”

「他希望從事科技行業。」

work in + field = 在某個專業、產業或工作領域發展／受僱

8. work = effort/labour (付出的努力) — 努力 ; 勞動; 功夫

This is broader than paid employment.

Practice 16

“Learning a language takes a lot of **work**.”

「學好一種語言需要花很多功夫和努力。」

Practice 17

“All that hard **work** finally paid off.”

「所有那些辛勤努力終於有了回報。」

work = 為完成目標而投入的體力、腦力、時間和努力

This can be unpaid.

9. **work = task(s) that need doing** (任務／工作量) — 工作；任務；事情

Practice 18

“I still have some **work** to finish.”

「我還有一些工作／事情要完成。」

Practice 19

“The repair involved more **work** than expected.”

「維修所需的工作量比預期多。」

work = 需要完成的一項或一批任務／工作內容

Usually uncountable when used collectively.

10. **schoolwork/coursework/homework-type work** (學業) — 功課；學習工作

Practice 20

“She finished her **work** before dinner.”

「她晚飯前完成了功課／學習工作。」

Practice 21

“The teacher checked the students’ **work**.”

「老師檢查了學生的作業／學習成果。」

work — education = 學生為課程、練習或學習而完成的作業／成果

This is a contextual branch of “task/output.”

11. a work = artistic/intellectual creation (藝術／文學作品) — 作品

Here **work** becomes countable.

Practice 22

“This painting is one of her best **works**.”

「這幅畫是她最出色的作品之一。」

Practice 23

“The museum displays several important **works** of modern art.”

「博物館展出幾件重要的現代藝術作品。」

a work / works = 一件由藝術家、作家或創作者完成的藝術／思想作品

So:

work = 工作 (通常不可數)

a work = 一件作品 (可數)

Very important.

12. the works of + author/artist (創作者) — 作品全集／作品

Practice 24

“She studies the **works of Shakespeare**.”

「她研究莎士比亞的作品。」

Practice 25

“His early **works** were very different.”

「他的早期作品很不一樣。」

works = 某位作者／藝術家創作的多件作品

13. **work = research/intellectual activity** (研究／學術工作) — 研究成果；工作

Practice 26

“Her **work** focuses on language learning.”

「她的研究工作集中於語言學習。」

Practice 27

“The scientist's **work** changed the field.”

「那名科學家的研究成果／工作改變了這個領域。」

work — academic = 某人進行的研究、分析或知識創造活動及其成果

14. **work = machine/device functions properly** (機器／設備) — 運作；正常工作

Now **work** is a verb.

Practice 28

“The headphones still **work** perfectly.”

「這副耳機仍然運作正常。」

Practice 29

“The button doesn’t **work**.”

「這個按鈕失靈／不能正常運作。」

work — machine = 機器、裝置或部件能按照設計正常發揮功能

This is a major distinct sense.

15. **work = system/software/service functions** (系統／軟件／服務) — 運作；有效運行

Practice 30

“The app doesn’t **work** on my phone.”

「這個應用程式在我的手機上不能正常運行。」

Practice 31

“The payment system is **working** again.”

「付款系統再次恢復正常運作。」

Same underlying concept as #14:
function correctly.

16. **work = plan/method/idea succeeds** (方法／計劃／策略) — 有效；行得通

This is the sense in:

“Another reason it **worked so well**...”

from later in your passage.

Practice 32

“The advertising strategy **worked**.”

「這個廣告策略奏效了／行得通。」

Practice 33

“If this approach doesn’t **work**, we’ll try another one.”

「如果這個方法不起作用／行不通，我們會試另一個。」

work — method/plan = 能夠產生預期結果，因此實際有效／行得通

This is conceptually related to a machine “working”:
both mean **performing its intended function successfully**.

17. **work = medicine/treatment has effect** (藥物／治療) — 奏效；產生作用

Practice 34

“The medicine started to **work** after twenty minutes.”

「藥物二十分鐘後開始產生作用／奏效。」

Practice 35

“This treatment does not **work** for everyone.”

「這項治療並不是對所有人都有效。」

work — treatment = 能產生預期的身體／治療效果

Same broad “be effective” sense.

18. work = operate/control a machine/device (操作設備) — 操作; 使用

This is transitive.

Practice 36

“Do you know how to **work** this machine?”

「你知道怎樣操作這部機器嗎？」

Practice 37

“She quickly learned to **work** the controls.”

「她很快學會了怎樣操作控制裝置。」

work something = 操作、控制或使用某台機器／系統，使它運作

Compare:

“The machine works.”

= 機器自己運作。

“She works the machine.”

= 她操作機器。

19. work + material (材料) — 加工; 塑造; 處理

A common craft/manufacturing meaning.

Practice 38

“The metal is easy to **work**.”

「這種金屬很容易加工／塑形。」

Practice 39

“The craftsperson **worked** the clay by hand.”

「工匠用手塑造／加工黏土。」

work a material = 透過切割、塑形、敲打、揉捏等方式改變材料形狀／性質

20. work + muscles/body part (身體部位) — 鍛鍊；使……活動

Practice 40

“This exercise **works** the shoulders.”

「這個運動可以鍛鍊肩膀肌肉。」

Practice 41

“Swimming **works** the whole body.”

「游泳可以鍛鍊全身。」

work a muscle/body part = 使某些肌肉或身體部位活動、用力並受到鍛鍊

21. work + person/team (使人工作／安排人工作) — 使工作；調動

Practice 42

“The manager **worked** the staff very hard.”

「經理讓員工工作得非常辛苦。」

Practice 43

“They **worked** the team long hours.”

「他們讓團隊長時間工作。」

work someone = 使某人投入工作或勞動，尤其指工作量很大

Can sound negative depending on context.

22. **work = gradually produce/change something through effort** (逐步使改變) — 努力使.....達成／改變

Practice 44

“She **worked** the material into the required shape.”

「她逐步把材料加工成所需形狀。」

Practice 45

“He slowly **worked** the key into the lock.”

「他慢慢把鎖匙弄進鎖孔。」

work = 透過反覆、持續的動作或努力，逐步令某物移動／改變狀態

This is less central but useful.

23. **work = influence/manage people skillfully** (人際／社交) — 經營；善用；設法影響

A common figurative use.

Practice 46

“She knows how to **work** a crowd.”

「她很懂得怎樣帶動／掌握群眾氣氛。」

Practice 47

“A good salesperson knows how to **work** the room.”

「好的銷售員懂得怎樣在場合中與不同人互動並建立關係。」

work a crowd/room = 巧妙地與群眾／在場人士互動，以取得注意、支持或良好反應

This is figurative and informal.

24. **work** = make efforts toward a goal (為目標努力) — 努力; 致力

Practice 48

“They **worked** for years to improve the product.”

「他們多年來一直努力改善產品。」

Practice 49

“We need to **work** together to solve the problem.”

「我們需要一起努力解決問題。」

work = 為達成某個目標投入持續努力

This goes beyond employment.

25. **working** = **employed** / **having a job** (人) — 有工作的; 在職的

Practice 50

“The programme supports **working parents**.”

「這項計劃支援在職父母。」

Practice 51

“Most **working adults** have limited free time.”

「大多數在職成年人的空閒時間有限。」

working + person = 正在受僱、從事工作的人

26. **working** = **functioning** (機器／設備) — 可運作的; 正常工作的

Practice 52

“We finally have a **working prototype**.”

「我們終於有一個能正常運作的原型。」

Practice 53

“Is the microphone in **working condition**?”

「麥克風是否處於可正常運作的狀態？」

working = 能夠實際運作、發揮所需功能的

27. **working** = provisional/practical version (版本／假設) — 暫定的；目前採用的

A useful academic/business meaning.

Practice 54

“This is our **working definition**.”

「這是我們目前採用的暫定定義／操作性定義。」

Practice 55

“They developed a **working hypothesis**.”

「他們建立了一個目前用來指導研究的暫定假設。」

working + idea/definition/hypothesis = 為了目前實際使用而暫時採用、之後仍可能修改的

Very useful in academic English.

28. **working** = knowledge sufficient for **practical use** (知識／語言能力) — 實用程度的；足以應用的

Practice 56

“She has a **working knowledge** of French.”

「她具備足以實際應用的法語知識。」

Practice 57

“You need a basic **working knowledge** of spreadsheets.”

「你需要具備基本而能實際操作應用的試算表知識。」

working knowledge = 雖未必精通，但已足以在實際情況中使用的知識

29. worker = person who works (工作者／員工) — 工人；工作人員；員工

Practice 58

“The company employs thousands of **workers**.”

「公司僱用了數千名員工／工人。」

Practice 59

“Office **workers** often spend long hours sitting.”

「辦公室工作者經常長時間坐著。」

worker = 從事工作的人；具體中文依行業可譯工人、員工、工作者

30. worker = person characterized by how hard/effectively they work —的工作者

Practice 60

“She is a hard **worker**.”

「她是一個工作很勤奮的人。」

Practice 61

“He is a very efficient **worker**.”

「他是一位工作效率很高的人。」

worker = 從工作態度／效率角度描述一個人

31. workable = capable of succeeding in practice — 可行的; 實際行得通的

A very useful family member.

Practice 62

“We need a **workable solution**.”

「我們需要一個實際可行的解決方案。」

Practice 63

“The idea sounds good, but is it **workable**?”

「這個想法聽起來不錯，但實際行得通嗎？」

workable = 在現實條件下可以實施並有合理成功可能的

32. workable = material that can be shaped/processed — 易加工的; 可塑的

A technical extension.

Practice 64

“The material becomes more **workable** when heated.”

「這種材料加熱後會變得更容易加工塑形。」

Practice 65

“The clay must remain soft and **workable**.”

「黏土必須保持柔軟而且可以加工塑造。」

workable — material = 物料的狀態允許人容易加工、塑形或處理

33. workmanship = quality/skill of how something was made — 做工；工藝；手藝品質

A very useful family extension.

Practice 66

“The headphones show excellent **workmanship**.”

「這副耳機的做工／工藝品質非常出色。」

Practice 67

“Poor **workmanship** caused the damage.”

「施工／製作工藝不良造成了損壞。」

workmanship = 製造、施工或手工製作中所展現的技巧和品質

Especially common in:

- construction
 - furniture
 - manufacturing
 - crafts
-

34. workplace = place where people work — 工作場所；職場

Practice 68

“Noise is a common **workplace** problem.”

「噪音是常見的職場問題。」

Practice 69

“The company promotes **workplace** safety.”

「公司推動工作場所安全。」

workplace = 人們進行受僱工作的地方／工作環境

It can mean:

- physical workplace;
 - broader organizational work environment.
-

35. **workforce** = all workers available/employed — 勞動人口；員工總體；勞動力

Practice 70

“The company has a global **workforce**.”

「公司擁有遍布全球的員工團隊／勞動力。」

Practice 71

“Technology is changing the **workforce**.”

「科技正在改變勞動市場中的工作人口結構。」

workforce = 一個企業、行業或國家中所有從事／可從事工作的人

36. **workshop** = place where things are made/repaired — 工場；工作室

Practice 72

“The furniture is made in a small **workshop**.”

「家具在一間小型工場／工作室製作。」

Practice 73

“He repairs bicycles in his **workshop**.”

「他在自己的工場修理單車。」

workshop — place = 進行製作、修理或手工工作的場所

37. **workshop = interactive training session** — 工作坊；研習班

A genuinely distinct modern meaning.

Practice 74

“I attended a writing **workshop**.”

「我參加了一個寫作工作坊。」

Practice 75

“The company organized a leadership **workshop**.”

「公司舉辦了一個領導力工作坊／培訓活動。」

workshop — event = 參加者透過討論、練習和實作共同學習某項技能的小型互動培訓活動

38. **overwork = work too much / make someone work too much** — 過度工作；使過勞

Practice 76

“He tends to **overwork**.”

「他很容易工作過度／過勞。」

Practice 77

“The company was accused of **overworking** its staff.”

「公司被指控讓員工過度工作。」

overwork = 工作時間、強度或負擔超過健康／合理程度

39. **overworked** = exhausted/burdened by too much work — 過勞的；工作負擔過重的

Practice 78

“Many employees feel **overworked**.”

「很多員工感到工作過量／過勞。」

Practice 79

“The department is understaffed and **overworked**.”

「部門人手不足，員工亦工作負擔過重。」

overworked = 因工作量或工時過多而承受過度負擔的

40. **works** = factory/industrial site (工廠／工程設施) — 工廠；工場；工程設施

This plural-looking noun has an important specialized use.

Practice 80

“He works at a steel **works**.”

「他在一家鋼鐵廠工作。」

Practice 81

“The water **works** supplies the surrounding area.”

「這座自來水處理／供水設施為附近地區供水。」

works = 進行大型製造、加工或公共工程運作的工業設施

Common compounds:

- steelworks = 鋼鐵廠
 - gasworks = 煤氣廠／燃氣設施
 - waterworks = 供水工程／供水設施
-

41. public works (政府工程) — 公共工程

A useful family extension.

Practice 82

“The government invested heavily in **public works**.”

「政府大量投資公共工程。」

Practice 83

“The project is part of a wider **public works** programme.”

「這個項目是大型公共工程計劃的一部分。」

public works = 由政府／公共機構建造或維護的道路、橋樑、供水等基礎設施工程

Important distinction: work vs job

One of the most important distinctions.

work

= activity/tasks/effort; usually uncountable.

“I have a lot of work.”

「我有很多工作。」

job

= a particular paid position or specific task; countable.

“I have a new job.”

「我有一份新工作。」

So:

a lot of work ✓

many works ✗ for ordinary job tasks

three jobs ✓

Important distinction: work vs workplace

work

can mean employment/activity.

“I’m at work.”

workplace

specifically means the environment/place where work happens.

“Workplace safety is important.”

「工作場所安全很重要。」

Important distinction: work vs career

work

= employment/activity you do.

career

= longer-term professional path over years.

“I have a lot of work this week.”

vs.

“She has had a successful career in advertising.”

「她在廣告業有成功的職業生涯。」

Important distinction: work vs labour/labor

work

broad and neutral.

labour/labor

often emphasizes:

- physical effort;
- workforce;
- economic labour.

“manual labour”

= 體力勞動

“I have work to do.”

= 我有工作要做。

Not always interchangeable.

Important distinction: work vs task

work

can refer to a whole amount/category of activity.

task

one specific piece of work with a defined objective.

“I have a lot of work.”

vs.

“My first task is to answer these emails.”

Important distinction: work vs operate

For machines:

work

= function successfully.

“The machine works.”

operate

= function/run, or someone controls it.

“The machine operates automatically.”

“She operates the machine.”

So:

work emphasizes effectiveness/functionality.

operate emphasizes running/control.

Important distinction: work vs function

function

more formal/technical.

“The system functions correctly.”

work

normal everyday English.

“The system works.”

Both:

「系統運作正常。」

Important distinction: work vs succeed

work

for a method:

= produce the intended effect.

succeed

for a person/plan:

= achieve a desired result.

“The method worked.”

「方法奏效。」

“The project succeeded.”

「項目成功了。」

Related, but not interchangeable everywhere.

Important distinction: work vs effective

Your passage uses both.

work — verb

“The ad worked.”

= 廣告奏效了。

effective — adjective

“The ad was effective.”

= 廣告是有效的。

Same broad concept, different grammar.

Important distinction: working vs workable

working

= currently functioning.

“a working prototype”

「能正常運作的原型」

workable

= capable of being implemented successfully.

“a workable plan”

「可行的計劃」

So:

working = 已經能運作

workable = 理論／實際上能夠行得通

Important distinction: worker vs employee

worker

very broad:

anyone who works; sometimes especially manual/operational work.

employee

specifically someone legally/employment-wise employed by an employer.

A self-employed person is a **worker**, but not necessarily an **employee**.

Important distinction: workmanship vs quality

quality

broad overall standard.

workmanship

specifically the skill/quality evident in how something was physically made.

“The materials are excellent, but the workmanship is poor.”

「材料很好，但做工很差。」

Very useful for product reviews.

Important countability note: work

Usually uncountable:

“I have a lot of work.”

Not:

I have many works. ❌

Countable when meaning creative works:

“three works by Mozart”

「莫札特的三部作品」

So this is a major meaning/countability shift.

Important grammar note: work for / as / at / in

This set is worth memorizing:

Pattern	Meaning
work for + employer	為某公司／僱主工作
work as + job	擔任某職業
work at + workplace	在某工作場所工作
work in + industry/field	從事某行業／領域

Example:

“She **works for** Apple **as** an engineer **at** its Seattle office **in** software development.”

Each preposition tells us something different.

Family-extension sweep

After the full sweep, the useful modern family includes:

- **work — employment** = 工作
- **at work** = 正在工作／在工作場所
- **work for + employer** = 為……工作
- **work as + job** = 擔任……
- **work at/in + workplace** = 在……工作
- **work in + field** = 從事……領域
- **work — effort** = 努力／功夫
- **work — task/workload** = 工作量／任務
- **work — education** = 學業／作業
- **a work / works** = 藝術／文學作品
- **work — academic** = 研究工作／成果
- **work — machine** = 運作
- **work — system/software** = 正常運行
- **work — plan/method** = 奏效／行得通
- **work — treatment** = 產生作用
- **work a machine** = 操作機器
- **work material** = 加工／塑造
- **work muscles** = 鍛鍊肌肉

- **work someone** = 使某人工作
- **work a room/crowd** = 經營現場互動／帶動群眾
- **working — employed** = 在職的
- **working — functioning** = 能運作的
- **working definition/hypothesis** = 暫定而供實際使用的
- **working knowledge** = 足以實際應用的知識
- **worker** = 工作者／員工
- **workable** = 可行的；可加工的
- **workmanship** = 做工／工藝品質
- **workplace** = 工作場所／職場
- **workforce** = 勞動力／員工總體
- **workshop — place** = 工場／工作室
- **workshop — training** = 工作坊
- **overwork** = 過度工作
- **overworked** = 過勞／工作負擔過重的
- **works — industrial site** = 工廠／工程設施
- **public works** = 公共工程

I'm deliberately excluding the enormous phrasal-verb family such as **work out**, **work through**, **work around**, **work up**, because our standing rule is no phrasal verbs by default.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
work — employment	一個人為職業、崗位或僱主進行的日常工作活動
work — effort	為完成目標投入的體力、腦力、時間和努力
work — task/workload	需要完成的一項或一批任務／工作內容
work — education	學生為課程、練習或學習而完成的作業／成果
a work / works	藝術家、作家或創作者完成的一件／多件作品
work — academic	某人進行的研究、分析或知識創造活動及成果
work — machine/device	機器、裝置或部件能按照設計正常發揮功能
work — system/software	系統或軟件能正常運行並提供預期功能
work — plan/method	方法或策略實際能產生預期結果；奏效／行得通

work — treatment	藥物／治療能產生預期作用
work a machine	操作、控制某台機器或設備
work material	透過加工、塑形等方式改變材料
work muscles	使特定肌肉／身體部位活動並受到鍛鍊
work someone	使某人投入工作, 尤其指工作量較大
work a room/crowd	巧妙與現場人士互動, 以取得注意、支持或良好反應
working — employed	正在受僱、從事工作的
working — functioning	已能正常運作、發揮所需功能的
working definition/hypothesis	為目前實際使用而暫時採用、之後仍可能修改的
working knowledge	未必精通, 但足以在實際情況中使用的知識
worker	從事工作的人; 員工／工人／工作者
workable — plan	在現實條件下可實施並有合理成功可能的
workable — material	狀態允許容易加工、塑形或處理的
workmanship	製造、施工或手工製作中展現的技巧和做工品質
workplace	人們進行受僱工作的地方／職場環境
workforce	某企業、行業或地區所有工作人口／勞動力
workshop — place	進行製作、修理或手工工作的場所
workshop — event	以討論、實作和練習為主的小型互動培訓活動
overwork	工作時間、強度或負擔超過合理／健康程度
overworked	因工作量或工時太多而承受過度負擔的
works — industrial	進行大型製造、加工或公共工程運作的工業設施
public works	由政府／公共機構建造或維護的公共基礎設施工程

For your original sentence

“I saw it about a year ago when I was watching television late at night **after work**.”

The exact meaning is:

work = 說話者日常受僱工作以及當天的工作時段

Therefore:

after work

= 「下班後／完成當天工作之後」

And later in the same passage:

“Another reason it **worked so well**...”

the same spelling has a completely different meaning:

worked = 奏效了／成功產生預期效果

So your passage itself already gives us two very different uses:

after work → 工作／上班

it worked well → 奏效／有效

That makes **work** one of the strongest polysemy words in the entire passage.